

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Last week: DJIA 41938.45 ▼ 793.68 1.86%

NASDAQ 19161.63 ▼ 2.3%

STOXX 600 511.50 ▲ 0.7%

10-YR. TREASURY (Reopening) yield 4.772%

OIL \$76.57 ▲ \$2.61

EURO \$1.0255

YEN 157.70

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **China's exports** to the rest of the world grew 5.9% last year to \$3.6 trillion, leaving it more dependent on exports than it has been for most of the past two decades and more vulnerable to trade threats from President-elect Donald Trump. **A1**
- ◆ **A federal subsidy** for leasing electric vehicles has made that option attractive to drivers, pushing leases to about 45% of EV transactions in the third quarter. **A1**
- ◆ **Steve Cohen's Point72** had a return in 2024 of about 19% in its flagship fund, according to people familiar with the matter, beating peers and indexes tracking the broader hedge-fund industry. **B1**
- ◆ **JPMorgan Chase shut** down comments on an internal webpage announcing the bank's return-to-office policy after dozens of them criticized the move and at least one suggested that affected employees should unionize. **B3**
- ◆ **Medalist Partners** aims to raise \$750 million for its fourth private-credit fund focused on asset-based lending, according to people familiar with the matter. **B3**
- ◆ **JCPenney merged** with Sparc, the owner of Aéro-postale and Brooks Brothers, to form a new clothing business called Catalyst Brands. **B5**
- ◆ **Venture capitalists** predicting trends for 2025 see a rebound in initial public offerings and M&A activity. **B4**
- ◆ **The U.S. Supreme Court** is expected to rule soon on the national injunction issued by a lower court that paused the implementation of a law requiring companies to disclose their true ownership. **B5**

World-Wide

- ◆ **The death count** from California wildfires rose to 24 as crews fighting the blazes in Los Angeles got some respite from the savage winds that whipped the flames into a sixth day, though officials warned that the reprieve could be short-lived. **A1, A5-6, A8**
- ◆ **The South** was slowly thawing in warmer weather that followed a winter storm that shut schools, cut power and canceled or delayed travelers' flights. **A2**
- ◆ **Hamas is reconstituting** its fighting forces under Mohammed Sinwar, a younger brother of Yahya Sinwar, whom Israel's military killed in Gaza in October. **A1**
- ◆ **Sen. Joni Ernst**, a former Army National Guard commander, is in the spotlight as she prepares to weigh in at a confirmation hearing Tuesday for Pete Hegseth as defense secretary. **A4**
- ◆ **Iran has shipped** nearly three million barrels of oil from a storage site in China in a bid to raise funds that could be used to shore up Tehran's allied militia groups in the Middle East. **A18**
- ◆ **Italy released from jail** Iranian businessman Mohammad Abedini, who is wanted by the Justice Department, as part of a deal coordinated with Trump that secured the release of an Italian journalist detained in Tehran. **A18**
- ◆ **The Justice Department** issued a report that found that the 1921 Tulsa Race Massacre was a coordinated, military-style effort to ruin the wealthy Black community in that Oklahoma city. **A3**

CONTENTS	
Arts in Review..... A13	Markets Digest..... B9
Business & Finance B24-6	Opinion..... A15-17
Business News..... B3	Personal Journal A11-12
Capital Account..... A2	Sports..... A14
Crossword..... A14	U.S. News..... A2-8
Finance & Markets..... B9	World News..... A10,18



A utilities worker on Sunday viewed damage from the Palisades Fire in the Pacific Palisades neighborhood in Los Angeles.

L.A. Officials Race to Fight Rumors, Conspiracy Theories

By SCOTT CALVERT
AND JOSHUA CHAFFIN

Los Angeles Fire Department Capt. Erik Scott has one of the most intense jobs in the nation right now: trying to distribute accurate public information during a historically destructive urban fire in America.

On Thursday, a new unexpected foe cropped up: Alex Jones, among the world's most notorious conspiracy theorists, was posting on X that L.A. firefighters were battling the blazes using ladies'

handbags as buckets because officials had donated equipment to Ukraine. The post has been viewed 29 million times.

Scott, the LAFD public-information officer, quickly explained publicly that the "handbags," were actually canvas bags routinely carried by firefighters to douse small fires, because that is easier and faster than hauling out and connecting hoses.

"We're trying to battle the most devastating natural disaster in Los Angeles history," Scott said by phone on Satur-

day while driving to base camp on the fifth day of the wildfire ordeal. "It takes people and time to track down or debunk social media rumors—it takes us away from doing more important things."

Fast-proliferating online falsehoods are forcing public officials nationwide to adopt a new job when crisis strikes their communities. Their duties now include knocking down the inevitable wave of lies, half-truths and conspiracy theories—some wild, some believable—that have of late

become part of every major public emergency, from Hurricane Helene to the recent Tesla explosion in Las Vegas.

This more assertive approach to debunking rumors is part of a playbook officials around the U.S. are increasingly turning to during natural disasters, high-profile crimes and contentious debates about issues like immigration.

At the same time, social-media platforms are complicating their task by loosening the

Forecast For Wind Keeps Fire Threat Very High

California death toll climbs to 24, with the major blazes largely uncontained

LOS ANGELES—Firefighters expected conditions to worsen as winds pick up in Los Angeles after the crews made progress this weekend against the raging fires that California Gov. Gavin Newsom projected will be the worst natural disaster in U.S. history.

By Ginger Adams Otis,
Sara Randazzo
and Belle Cushing

Intensifying Santa Ana winds are expected to move in by Monday and remain until Wednesday. The death count rose to 24, officials said.

Some residents displaced by the disaster were allowed to return to their homes Sunday afternoon after evacuation orders were lifted for sections of neighborhoods around the two largest blazes in Los Angeles County, the Eaton and Palisades fires. In other areas directly hit by the fires, residents' access is still limited because of the danger of smoldering embers and hazardous gases.

Relatively low humidity and abundant dry vegetation continue to complicate efforts to knock down flames, particularly

Please turn to page A6

- ◆ **Residents visit ruins, once their homes.....** A5
- ◆ **Why seawater is a last-ditch option.....** A6
- ◆ **Celebrities play a role as tragedy unfolds.....** A8
- ◆ **Heard on the Street: An insurance safety valve... B10**

Deals on Leases Drive EV Market

By CHRISTOPHER OTTS

Toyota Motor's only electric vehicle widely on sale in the U.S. starts at about \$37,000. But practically nobody plunks down that much for the mid-size SUV, named bZ4X.

"Almost everyone leases the car," Toyota U.S. sales chief David Christ said in a recent interview. "You'd be a fool not to."

The Japanese-made SUV, which qualifies for a \$7,500 federal subsidy only if it is leased, illustrates a broader shift in the way car companies are marketing electric cars to consumers, with more-afford-

able monthly payments and no long-term commitment.

People who leased the Toyota in 2024 paid \$445 a month on average, compared with \$717 for those who financed the car through a purchase loan, according to credit bureau Experian.

The proliferation of lease deals has made EVs more accessible to buyers who couldn't afford their higher sticker prices. For the automakers, it is helping get more EVs into customers' hands after a choppy start for their electric-car operations.

There is a potential pitfall

Please turn to page A2

INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL
It's a jubilee year in Italy, which was already grappling with overtourism. **A11**

BUSINESS & FINANCE
Skechers scores with focus on casual shoes, a market neglected by its competitors. **B1**

China Export Boom Raises Vulnerability To Trump Tariffs

By JASON DOUGLAS

China's economy is more dependent on exports than it has been for most of the past two decades, leaving it vulnerable to a new broadside on trade from President-elect Donald Trump.

Chinese exports to the rest of the world grew by 5.9% last year compared with a year earlier to \$3.6 trillion, figures published Monday showed.

Those figures mean trade is on track to account for about

a fifth of the 5% or so growth China is expected to report this year.

Aside from 2021, when consumers the world over were gorging on Chinese-made home appliances, fitness equipment and computer gear during Covid-19 lockdowns, that would mark trade's biggest contribution to Chinese economic growth since 2006, when

Please turn to page A2

- ◆ **Greg Ip: Trump economist makes tariff case.....** A2

The Falconer: RFK Jr.'s Other Identity

* * *
Avian hobby extends to hawks, ravens, pigeons

By KRISTINA PETERSON

WASHINGTON—When Robert F. Kennedy, Jr. gathered his 2024 presidential campaign team for a meeting, he elbowed his neighbor to point at the window: several falcons were flying through the air.

Long before he was a vaccine skeptic, presidential candidate and president-elect Trump's pick to lead the Health and Human Services Department, Kennedy got hooked on falconry. The sport, in which wild birds of prey are trained to hunt with their handlers, hasn't let go.

So central is falconry to Kennedy's identity that a ballot

Please turn to page A4

Brother of Slain Leader Seeks to Rebuild Hamas

Hamas suffered a severe blow last fall when Israel killed Yahya Sinwar, the group's leader and strategist behind the Oct. 7, 2023, attacks.

By Summer Said,
Anat Peled
and Rory Jones

But now the U.S.-designated terrorist group has another Sinwar in charge, Yahya's younger brother Mohammed, and he is working to build the militant group back up.

Israel's 15-month campaign has reduced Hamas's Gaza Strip redoubt to rubble, killed thousands of its fighters and much of its leadership, and cut off the border crossings it might use to rearm. The well-trained and well-armed cadres that surged into southern Israel in October 2023 are badly weakened.

But the violence has also created a new generation of willing recruits and littered Gaza with unexploded ordnance Hamas

fighters can refashion into improvised bombs. The militant group is using those tools to continue to inflict pain. The Israeli military has reported in the past week 10 deaths among soldiers in the area of Beit Hanoun in northern Gaza. Hamas also has fired some 20 rockets at Israel in the past two weeks.

The recruitment drive and persistent fighting under Sinwar pose a fresh challenge for Israel. Its military has battered the group in Gaza, but for months has had to return to areas it previously cleared of militants to take them on again in new fighting. That cycle points to the difficulty of ending a war that has exhausted Israel's troops and continues to imperil hostages held in Gaza.

"We are in a situation where the pace at which Hamas is rebuilding itself is

Please turn to page A10

- ◆ **Syrians from Assad's sect fear reprisals.....** A10

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Agentforce What AI Was Meant to Be